Travel Agents: Taiwan — Rules Draft (v6.2)

0. The pitch (read aloud, 20 seconds)

"You're rival travel agents building the best Taiwan food tour in one eating day. Ride between four regions, dig ingredients from each market, and pile Buzz on the vendors you want. Win one by out-hyping your rival on the spot — each vendor makes the next cheaper and climbs your Prestige and Reputation. Book Tour Tickets and finish them before dusk flips the street to the neon night market; when the last train's called, catch it home. Best tour is Top Agent."

1. Goal

Score the most points — from your vendors' Prestige, your Reputation standing, and your Tour Tickets (win-pile − lose-pile). Most = Top Agent.

2. Setup (teach while you set up)

1. Unfold the Taiwan map — four regions in a ring, North 北 · Central 中 · South 南 · East 東, an HSR spine linking North↔South. It holds the day-clock track (a dusk mark and a last-train mark), the Prestige and Reputation tracks, and

— per region — a face-down vendor deck with face-up vendor slots (North 2, the others 1) and a face-down ingredient market deck. Set every marker to 0.

2. Sort each region's cards into a DAY deck and a NIGHT deck (drinks are the low-value vendors mixed into each); set the night decks aside for dusk. Shuffle each day vendor deck and day ingredient deck face-down into place. Ingredient decks use the 5-palette (N 豬肉 · C 茶 · S 海鮮 · E 米 + the common K 糖, in C & S only) plus a few event cards (§6). Fill the face-up vendor slots. Set out the Buzz supply (~24 @2p).
3. Tour Tickets: shuffle the daytime pool, draw 5 (rest to the box), reveal 3 as the shared ticket row (the other 2 form its draw pile, with a few general-pool tickets shuffled in). Repeat with the nighttime pool; set it aside for dusk.
4. Each agent takes an Agent Character (ability + flaw — read aloud, public) and a pawn (start opposite at 2p — one North, one South). Your Larder starts empty and stays face-up all game.

3. How a turn works (the core loop — teach these six, then just play)

Do ONE action. Then if your Larder holds over 7 ingredients, discard down to 7 (to that region's market discard, which reshuffles in when the deck runs dry — ingredients are never removed from the game).

- VISIT THE LOCAL MARKET (where you stand) — flip the top 3 of this region's ingredient deck. Any event happens now

(by its scope — §6), then is discarded. Keep up to 2 ingredients, discard the rest.

- CONVENIENCE STORE (anywhere) — flip the top 1 card of any region's ingredient deck: an ingredient → take it; an event → it fires by its scope (§6). (Any region, no travel — the reliable way to grab the common K.)
- TRAVEL — move to a neighbouring region (HSR = North↔South), then flip the top 1 card of the region you arrive in: ingredient → take it; event → nothing, keep moving.
- PROMOTE (with the vendor, in this region) — place 2 Buzz from the supply onto vendor(s) you're with here. Buzz stays on the card for all to see; your rival can pile on too.
- BRIBE A VENDOR — win a face-up vendor by out-hyping your rival, on the spot (§4–§5). (Winning any vendor moves the day-clock +1.)
- CLAIM A TOUR TICKET — take one ticket from the face-up row of 3 (the current phase's pool) as an open commitment; refill the row. You may only claim one you haven't yet completed. It scores later into your win-pile / lose-pile (§8–§9).

> Agent Characters bend the rules. Each mat carries one ability + one flaw for that agent alone (e.g. the competitive eater keeps all 3 on a Visit) — read every mat aloud at setup; a mat wins where it differs from the above.

4. Buzz — the hype fight (the heart of it)

You show a vendor you want them with Buzz — you promise crowds and hype (your job: bring people to the food). - Buzz only ever sits in the supply or on a vendor — never in your hand. - To Buzz a vendor you must be standing in its region. - Both agents can pile Buzz on the same vendor — that's the fight, and it's where the game is won.

5. Bribing a vendor (winning it over) — ONE rule for every vendor

To Bribe a face-up vendor, all at once: 1. be with the vendor, in its region; 2. hold at least 2 more Buzz on it than your rival (the majority, checked right now); 3. pay its ingredients, minus your region discounts (below). Take the vendor to your tour and gain its Prestige (score marker up), its Reputation (Rep marker up), and its perk. Then clear ALL Buzz on it (yours and your rival's) back to the supply, refill the slot from that region's current deck, and move the day-clock +1 (§7). The vendor is locked from your rival.

> The engine (the "aha"). Each food vendor carries a region icon; every matching icon you hold makes that region's ingredients 1 cheaper on future vendors — sign a couple of Southern stalls and the next barely needs oysters. Drinks carry no icon and no ramp (worth 2 Prestige) — a cheap grab, never a win on their own. Buzz is never discounted, so the hype fight, not the ingredients, gates your next big win.

Outraced, not robbed. If your rival out-hypes you, your Buzz just fizzles back to the supply — you keep every ingredient you sourced, and a fresh vendor comes out. You never seize a place.

6. The market decks & events (the island doesn't sit still)

Each region's market is a face-down deck of its signature ingredient (+ the common K, in two of the four regions) and a few event cards (mostly hazards). Working a market — a Visit or a Convenience Store — fires any flipped event straight away, by its scope; a card flipped as you arrive on a Travel does nothing. - Hazards (the majority) — a typhoon, a "完售 SOLD OUT" sign, scooter gridlock. They tax or delay — never destroy what you hold, never cost a whole turn. - Boons (the minority) — a festival that hands out Buzz, a kind auntie, or a vendor suddenly gets hot (★ below).

The scope tag — who the event hits, measured from the region the card came out of: ⦿ You (just the flipper) · ⬢ This region (everyone standing in the drawn region) · ➤ Next door (someone in a neighbour). Worked example: on a Visit you stand in the region you flipped, so ⬢ hits you; on a Convenience Store you're often elsewhere, so ⬢ hits whoever stands in the region you flipped — flip a rival's region and a scoped hazard can land on them. Never a personal attack — just the island living its life.

★ Star vendors. Some night-market names carry a printed ★ (a real Michelin / Bib-Gourmand nod), score top Prestige, and sit one apex per region — the rotating prize both agents chase. A

> boon can also drop a ★ Star token on a vendor, making it worth +2 Prestige / +1 Rep to whoever wins it.

7. The day-clock — Day → Night (every vendor you win moves it)

It's one eating day. The day-clock climbs +1 every time anyone Bribes a vendor — food or drink alike. It has two marks (2p: dusk = the 5th table-wide vendor win · last train = the 10th; the marks grow with more players): - Act I — Daytime 白天: morning food + the day's drinks. Cheap and low-contest at first — build your discount ramp and stake early positions. Daytime Tour Tickets are on offer. - DUSK (the day-clock hits the dusk mark) — the street turns over. In one flip: judge every claimed DAYTIME ticket (completed → win-pile · unfinished → lose-pile — §9); then clear the entire day layer island-wide — every face-up and face-down day vendor deck AND day ingredient deck — and replace it with each region's night decks (a neon recolour, run event-heavier). Swap the ticket row to the nighttime pool. You keep your Larder. Any unclaimed day vendor is gone. - Act II — Night Market 夜市: the big night-market stalls — expensive, fought-over, the ★ apex per region. This is where the tour is won.

(The faster you all win vendors, the faster the day moves — a built-in catch-up for a slow, tall player.)

8. Ending the trip — the last train home

When the day-clock hits the last-train mark (2p: the 10th vendor win), everyone catches the last train: finish the current round, play one more full round, and stop. (Backstop: if a region's deck empties, its slot isn't refilled until the next flip; if all decks dry island-wide, the phase ends then. Reaching the top of Reputation scores its reward but does not end the game. If one win trips dusk and the last train at once, resolve dusk first, then the end check.)

9. Scoring — reveal your piles and tally once

Add up three vectors: 1. Prestige — the sum of your vendors' values (already on your track). 2. Reputation — the VP for your final position only (not cumulative): 3–5 → +2 · 6–8 → +4 · 9–11 → +6 · 12 → +9. 3. Tour Tickets — +the printed value of each ticket in your WIN pile, −floor(value ÷ 2) for each in your LOSE pile (half its own value, rounded down). Tickets are sorted into those piles as each phase ends (§7–§8); tally once, at game end — nothing changes during play.

Most points wins → Top Agent. Ties: highest Reputation, then most vendors, then most regions covered.

10. The warm-tone reminders (margin asides, not rules)

- You're promoting Taiwan's food — winning a vendor is out-hyping your rival to earn their blessing, never taking from

them. "Bribe" is the cheeky word; the deed is a warm hard sell, not corruption.

- Events are the island living its life — never sacred customs for laughs; a Convenience-Store event on your rival is the island doing it, a shared groan, never a spiteful strike. Dish and vendor names stay real (Tâi-lô + 繁體); the comedy is the caper gag and your own gluttony.